

A HISTORY OF GMAIL

Gmail is nearly ubiquitous today. Many of today's netizens can't remember email before Gmail. However in the nearly three years that led up to its launch, many doubts were cast over it. Time details the history of Gmail on its 10th anniversary, when privacy concerns have re-emerged. <http://dgit.in/wvGmail>

REMEMBER WALKMAN?

The iPod's been around for nearly 13 years, so you may not remember its predecessors. Like the Sony Walkman TPS-L2 the very first Walkman ever, launched in 1979. The device opened the market for portable music players. <http://dgit.in/wvWalkman>

PING!

One of the clues towards the location of lost MH370 flight was an incomplete 'ping' sent out by the aircraft. A ping is an electrical signal sent out by one device to get in touch with another, and its use has spilled over into colloquial English. But the use of the ping predates modern history, and even goes as far as World War II! <http://dgit.in/wvPing>

TMI ON THE INTERNET

The Internet, particularly social media seems to be optimised for sharing every last detail of your life with others. In such a set-up, is there such a thing as sharing too much? Does the fact that you opt-in to these status updates, tweets or photos somehow prevent you from complaining about it? <http://dgit.in/wvUnfollow>

Why the new Google Camera app isn't all that great

Simply put, the new Google Camera app is a step forward but also a giant leap in the reverse direction. Here's why.

- By Siddharth Parwatay

Last month, Google launched Google Camera, a new app for Android phones and tablets which Google claims "makes it easy to take quick photos and videos." Google also says that "being behind the lens just got more fun with new creative picture modes."

The app also adds Lens Blur feature, Improved Panorama and Photo Sphere images that can capture images of up to 50 megapixels! All great... But...

**Where are my settings?**

The new app lets you swipe in from the edge of the screen to reveal new "cool" features or photo modes. But what about regular... ahem... humdrum settings like self-timer, scene modes, white balance? In a quest for simplicity, Google has gone ahead and ditched these – in my opinion "essential settings." The only setting that you can bring back is Exposure but that too by going into advanced settings by tapping on the cog icon while the lens blur and panorama overlay are on.

100% viewfinder coverage

The previous app showed a 16:9 crop from a 4:3 sensor, just to fill the screen. Thus you only saw a part of an image in the viewfinder, whereas the actual captured images would be bigger. Now with the current update, what you see is what you get – a good thing. A step in the right direction. But did you really need that extra large capture button? I understand that you need to fill the extra space left from showing a 4:3 image on a 16:9 screen, but couldn't you use that space for on-screen settings? Is it worth having a shutter button on one-fifth of your screen? Ugh.

Lens Blur performance is hazy

Bad pun aside, shooting in lens blur mode isn't easy. It takes some getting used to and more than 50% of the time you will need to take the shot again. Once a shot is taken successfully, it takes a long time to process/render.

After that, on viewing the image with lens blur mode, you get an option to shift focus, allowing you to bring the desired part of the frame in focus and blur the rest. The feature works pretty fine for a software-based implementation. The slider at the bottom to adjust the blur intensity is a nice touch. Here are some samples with focus being shifted to dif-



Focus shifted on the blue Digit magazine cover (left) and focus shifted on the white DGT cover (right)



Focus shifted on the pencils close to the camera (left) and focus shifted on the pencils away from the camera (right)



ferent parts of the frame and comparison to the original frame shot with lens blur mode:

Note that the main image that you shoot with lens blur mode isn't the one you are supposed to use. You are expected to review the image and then choose the focus points and blur levels to get the desired image effect that you envisioned.

Verdict: You could either roll back the changes the update brings by going to "My Apps" in the Play Store and uninstall the app/update. That will bring back your camera app to previous stock versions, with all the settings and customization options.

You could also check out some of the top alternative camera apps that you can try out on your Android smartphone here: <http://dgit.in/dcamapps>